1

The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

The fiddler had been tuning his instrument since the chapel bell struck eleven, and by the time Alexander reached the gate he still had not found the elusive note he'd been searching for. The note wavered over the yard, went sharp, and sagged back. Nobody minded it except Mr. Fenwick, who was bellowing over it at a cider cart.

"Hold! Hard, the lot of you! She's in up to the axle. Walk that horse on and you'll have the wheel off and the barrels in the muck, and who'll drink it then?"

The cart had come in over the soft ground by the trough and settled there with the patience of a cow in a gateway. Four estate hands stood about the back of it, considering the problem. Alexander drew off his gloves, put them in his coat pocket, and set his shoulder to the tailboard beside Davies, who anchored the tug-of-war team every autumn and smelled of the tallow he worked into the rope.

Two of the men traded a look over his head. He was taller than either, so the look had to go round him rather than past him, and he gave it no attention whatever.

"On three, Master Alexander, if you please," Davies said.

They heaved on three. The wheel came out of the mire with the sound of a boot leaving a ditch, the barrels knocked together, and Fenwick called the horse something a curate would have had to look up. Alexander stepped back with a dark crescent of the yard on his sleeve and a pleasant ache in his shoulder. Nobody thanked him. He had not expected it, and he found, on examining the matter, that he would have minded if they had.

Across the yard, under the chestnuts where the first yellow had come into the leaves, his father stood at the judging table in his shirtsleeves. Farmer Hodge faced him across it with a marrow cradled in both arms like an infant at the font.

"By weight, your Grace," Hodge said. "Always has been by weight."

"It has been by weight," Edward agreed, "for the eleven years in which Mrs. Carrow has taken first prize." He laid two scarred fingers on the marrow's flank, as a man might lay them on a horse he meant to buy, and his face settled into the stillness Alexander had watched it hold over the county's tithe returns. "Water weighs a good deal, Mr. Hodge, and costs nothing. I put it to you. What does girth cost?"

Hodge opened his mouth and shut it again. From somewhere behind him, the Widow Carrow announced that she had heard that, thank you.

His mother had placed herself a little way off beside the cake stall, near enough to catch every word and too far for anyone to appeal to her. She caught his eye across the argument and lifted a hand to shade her face, and the thin silver lines across her palm took the sun for an instant before she lowered it. Her lips shaped, without sound, *Help him*. Then, as Edward embarked on the principle of the thing: *Don't.*

He did not. He had never once managed to argue a marrow with the gravity his father gave it, and he suspected this was a failing in him rather than in the marrow. He stood with his hands clasped behind his back, fingertips tapping his thumb in turn, until Thomas Barrow came to stand at his elbow. Barrow wore his good brown coat, far too good for a morning of trestles and hurdles, and there was already straw in the buttonholes.

"Saw you at Fenwick's cart, Master Alexander. He'll tell it after as though he lifted her single-handed, mind."

"He is entirely welcome to."

Barrow smiled at his boots. He watched the judging for a while, and then, in the voice of a man remarking on a change in the wind: "Fen's looking well. Hay's all in, and the eels are running thick below the sluice. That'll feed eleven families this winter, that will, with rents what they are."

"Eleven," Alexander said.

"Counted them myself." Barrow touched his hat and went off to settle an argument over the tug-of-war rope.

Alexander had known Harrow's Fen all his life as a line in the estate book: a long strip of water-meadow under the ridge, let in parcels, which his father would not sell and had never been asked to explain. He looked toward it now. The mist lay over it soft as muslin, and through it, one after another, he found the chimneys. The Davies cottage by the sluice. The Carrows', its whitewash gone grey. He could put a name to nine of them. The other two he would have by Michaelmas, and he was a little ashamed to need until then.

He went in by the scullery passage, which was the quick way to the kitchen and ran past the butler's pantry. Along that stretch he kept his eyes on the copper moulds hung on the opposite wall, fourteen of them, fish and wheatsheaf, and went down the row as he had since boyhood. Had anyone asked, he could not have said what colour the pantry door was painted.

The kitchen met him with a wall of heat and the smell of scalded cream. Mrs. Thompson had festival ribbons looped from the beams among the hams, and was telling a scullery maid to shift herself, love, or else make herself useful. On the great deal table, in a gown of pale green silk that had no business within a mile of a range, sat his sister. She had a tart balanced on her knee and flour up one cuff, and she was swinging her foot.

"Master Alexander." Catherine inclined her head from a seated position with such exactness that it amounted to a curtsey. "You honour our humble hearth, sir. Will you take a tart, or shall I have it carried up on a salver?" She was laughing before she reached the salver. "You've mud all down your arm. Did you push something? Was it Fenwick? Mrs. Thompson says the ribbons stay up till first frost, whatever Mamma says, and I said, well, what if there isn't a frost, what if the winter simply doesn't come this year and we all..."

The sentence stopped. Her gaze had gone past his shoulder to the high window, where there was nothing but the kitchen garden wall and, above it, the pale thread of the road running south between the elms.

"And we all what?" he asked.

"Hm?" She came back to him and held out half the tart. "What was I saying?"

He took it. Behind him Mrs. Thompson dropped a pan lid and called on the Lord, and Catherine was already looking at the glass again.

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Added Details not in Scene Packet

Here's a list of every detail in the draft that doesn't come from the scene packet, in the order it appears. I checked each item against the packet only. You said the bibles were already folded into it, but if anything below turns out to be in a bible after all, just strike it.

Festival yard

- The fiddler has been tuning since the chapel bell struck eleven and still hasn't found his A when Alexander arrives.
- Fenwick's shouted line uses the Norfolk phrase "Hold you hard" and warns that the wheel will come off and the barrels end up in the muck.
- The cart is stuck in soft ground by the trough.
- Alexander takes off his gloves and pockets them before pushing, and he pushes alongside Davies.
- Davies smells of tallow, which he works into the tug-of-war rope every autumn.
- The hands' look has to go "round" Alexander because he is taller than they are.
- Davies calls the push "On three, Master Alexander."
- Fenwick calls the horse something "a curate would have had to look up."
- Alexander's sleeve is left with a dark crescent of mud, and nobody thanks him, which he prefers.

Judging table

- Hodge cradles his marrow like an infant at the font and says it has "allus" been judged by weight.
- The Widow Carrow has won first prize for eleven years. The packet only says she is accused of watering her marrow for that long.
- Edward's argument is that water weighs a good deal and costs nothing, so what does girth cost?
- Edward lays two scarred fingers on the marrow the way a man touches a horse he means to buy.
- Alexander has seen that same stillness on his father's face over the county's tithe returns.
- The Widow Carrow calls out from the crowd that she heard that.
- Amelia stands beside the cake stall.
- Amelia's silver palm lines catch the sun when she shades her face.
- Amelia silently mouths "Help him" to Alexander, then "Don't."
- Alexander counts his inability to argue a marrow as a failing in himself.

Thomas Barrow and Harrow's Fen

- Barrow's coat is brown, and it already has straw in the buttonholes. The morning's work is trestles and hurdles.
- Barrow says Fenwick will later claim he lifted the cart single-handed.
- Barrow reports that the hay is in and the eels are running thick below the sluice, with "rents what they are."
- Barrow says of the eleven families, "Counted them myself."
- Barrow leaves to settle an argument over the tug-of-war rope.
- The Fen is described as a long strip of water-meadow under the ridge, let to tenants in parcels. It appears in the estate book, and Edward has never been asked to explain why he won't sell it.
- Mist lies over the Fen, and Alexander picks out its cottage chimneys.
- The Davies cottage stands by the sluice. The Carrows' cottage has whitewash gone grey.
- Alexander can name nine of the eleven families and means to learn the other two by Michaelmas.

Scullery passage

- Alexander's route to the kitchen is the scullery passage, which runs past the butler's pantry.
- On the wall opposite the pantry hang fourteen copper jelly moulds shaped like fish and wheatsheaves. Alexander has counted them since boyhood to keep from looking at the door.
- He could not say what colour the pantry door is painted.

Kitchen

- The kitchen smells of scalded cream.
- The festival ribbons are looped from the beams among the hams.
- Mrs. Thompson tells a scullery maid to "shift herself, love."
- The great table is a deal table.
- Catherine wears a pale green silk gown and swings her foot as she sits.
- Catherine greets Alexander as "Master Alexander," in mock ceremony, and offers to have his tart "carried up on a salver."
- Catherine calls her mother "Mamma."
- Catherine brings up the ribbons-until-first-frost rule during this scene, as Mrs. Thompson's current position. The packet places Mrs. Thompson's refusal later in the book.
- Catherine wonders aloud, "What if the winter simply doesn't come this year."

- The kitchen's high window shows the kitchen garden wall and, beyond it, a road running south between elms.
- Catherine gives Alexander half her tart.
- Mrs. Thompson drops a pan lid and calls on the Lord.

The items most likely to matter later are the Fen details (the eels, the sluice, the parcels, the nine known families), because they could shape Hessian's offer in Chapter 2. The south-facing road seen from the kitchen may also matter, since it could tie into Catherine's travel plans.